

Podcast Episode: Tactical Media, Urban Commons, and PROVO 4.2

Show Title: *Signals from the Commons* **Episode 42:** *From White Bikes to Audio Drops: The Resurgence of PROVO 4.2* **Format:** Co-hosted audio conversation (Host A & Host B)

[AUDIO INTRO: Low-fi synthetic chime, sound of Amsterdam traffic, a bike bell ringing in the distance, followed by a slight radio static crackle.]

HOST A: Welcome back to *Signals from the Commons*. Today, we are diving into an open-source, tactical media rabbit hole that sits right at the intersection of 1960s counterculture, physical urban hacking, and modern open-data archiving. We're talking about **PROVO 4.2**.

HOST B: If you've been keeping an eye on Zenodo under the **Rock Street** community, or following the attogram/science-park-has-fallen repository, you might have noticed some strange datasets dropping. Things titled *P42 PHONE 0000*, DOIs minted on wooden benches outside coffeeshops near Amsterdam Central Station, and hardware specs for low-cost audio installations.

HOST A: It sounds bizarre at first glance, but it's actually a meticulously documented project. So, to understand PROVO 4.2, we have to start where it all began: Amsterdam, May 1965. The original **Provo movement**.

HOST B: Right. Roel van Duijn, Rob Stolk, Robert Jasper Grootveld. They were provocateurs, anarchists, and artists. But instead of violence, they used what they called *ludieke acties*—playful actions—to provoke authority, spark debate, and reshape public space.

HOST A: And their most famous intervention was the **Witte Fietsenplan**—the White Bicycle Plan. They bought 50 bicycles, painted them white, left them unlocked around Amsterdam, and said: "*These belong to everyone. Use one, leave it for the next person.*"

HOST B: The police confiscated them almost immediately because municipal laws required bicycles to be locked! But that was the point. It exposed the absurdity of public space regulations and planted the seeds for modern bike-sharing systems.

HOST A: Fast forward to today. Enter **PROVO 4.2**. What is it, and why "4.2"?

HOST B: "4.2" is a dual nod. On one level, it's a homage to *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*—42 being the ultimate answer. But structurally, PROVO 4.2 represents **Version 4.2** of the original 1960s movement—a modern fork engineered for the digital age.

HOST A: It's spearheaded by contributors under the Attogram handle and documented publicly. Instead of just throwing ideas into public space, PROVO 4.2 treats physical urban interventions as open-source code and data.

HOST B: There are two main pillars to the project:

1. **White Bikes 4.2 (Witte Fietsen 4.2):** Modernizing the physical bike commons using standardized locks, 3D-printable key matrices hosted on Git, and decentralized public registries so anyone can maintain or unlock the shared fleet.
2. **Audio Dead Drops:** Deploying automated, self-contained audio/video broadcast units built from budget consumer hardware (€40 to €130).

HOST A: Let's talk about those Audio Drops. Take *P42 PHONE 0000*, which was recently logged on Zenodo under the Rock Street community. It's a prototype promotional phone—a Samsung device purchased at MediaMarkt via gift cards bought with Bitcoin. It was deployed on a bench near Central Station, complete with a minted DOI (Digital Object Identifier) right on the spot!

HOST B: Think about how brilliant that is from a legal and archival standpoint. Traditional graffiti or unauthorized public art gets cleaned up or removed by city authorities. But PROVO 4.2 operates within strict municipal boundaries—specifically targeting **99.9% compliance** with

Dutch APV (local police regulations) and the *Wet openbare manifestaties*.

HOST A: By minting academic DOIs on Zenodo for every physical hardware deployment, video file, or audio drop, they turn ephemeral, local tactical media into permanent, peer-reviewed public record. If the phone or speaker gets removed, the data, hardware specs, and audio content remain permanently archived on open data repositories.

HOST B: It challenges the line between civic art, institutional critique, and open science. AI models like Mistral, Grok, and Kimi have even been pulled into the loop to review and critique the manifests in GitHub Issue #33.

HOST A: It's essentially a live test of how modern technology—open-source software, crypto funding, decentralized data repositories, and budget hardware—can resurrect 1960s civic provocation.

HOST B: So, if you're ever walking through Science Park or around Amsterdam Central, keep your eyes open. Look for a white bike with *WB-042* stenciled on the frame, or listen for an audio drop broadcasting from a bench. The provocations haven't stopped; they've just gone open-source.

HOST A: That's all for today's episode. Check the show notes for links to the Rock Street Zenodo uploads and GitHub repository. Until next time, keep poking the system—playfully.

[AUDIO OUTRO: Bike bell chime fades out into ambient traffic noise.]